

ICOMOS

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Addendum 2 Evaluations of Nominations of Cultural and Mixed Properties

ICOMOS report for the World Heritage Committee
48th ordinary session of the World Heritage Committee
Busan, Republic of Korea / 19-29 July 2026

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2026

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Nominations submitted for processing on an emergency basis

VII Cultural properties

A Arab States

New nomination

State of Palestine [C 1809]

Sebastia

1

Nomination under evaluation

Lebanon [C 1810]

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14

VII Cultural properties

A Arab States

Nominations submitted for processing on an emergency basis

Sebastia (State of Palestine) No 1809

1 Basic information

Official name as proposed by the State Party

Sebastia

Location

Governorate of Nablus
State of Palestine

Brief description

Sebastia, located near Nablus in the West Bank, in Palestine, preserves the archaeological record of the successive occupation of the site by different civilisations from at least the 9th century BCE through the Hellenistic, Roman, and Byzantine periods, with later architectural remains dating to the Crusader era, as well as the Ayyubid/Mamluk and Ottoman periods, when it was one of the designated “Throne Villages”.

Category of property

In terms of categories of cultural property as set out in Article I of the 1972 World Heritage Convention, this is a *site*.

Included in the Tentative List

2 April 2012

Background

The nomination was submitted to the World Heritage Centre by the State Party on 27 April 2026 to be evaluated under an emergency evaluation procedure as set out in paragraphs 161 and 162 of the *Operational Guidelines for the Implementation of the World Heritage Convention*. It was transmitted to ICOMOS on 27 April 2026.

The nomination was submitted by the State Party as an emergency nomination because of the imminent threat of land expropriation of the substantial part of the nominated property by the Israeli Civil Administration, who plans to develop on the site the Shomron National Park; this would result in the irreversible alteration of the site. Moreover, the emergency nomination follows the intensified physical threats and violations to the archaeological site that is not under the control of the State Party (Area C), and particularly the unauthorised excavations, confiscation of archaeological material, destruction of structures on the site, and damage from military incursions and heavy machinery movements.

This is a new nomination.

Consultations and technical evaluation mission

Desk reviews have been provided by ICOMOS International Scientific Committees, members and independent experts.

ICOMOS, in consultation with the World Heritage Centre, considered the feasibility of a technical evaluation mission to the nominated property. However, given the safety and security conditions, the mission could not take place.

Additional information received by ICOMOS

A letter was sent to the State Party on 7 May 2026 requesting further information about the prolonged threats to the integrity of the nominated property and the emergency situation, artefacts, the cathedral/mosque, legal protection and management, the buffer zone, documentation, maps, and photographs.

Additional information was received from the State Party on 29 May 2026.

All additional information received has been incorporated into the relevant sections of this evaluation report.

Date of ICOMOS approval of this report

23 June 2026

2 Description of the nominated property

Note: The nomination dossier and additional information contain detailed descriptions of this property, its history and its state of conservation. Due to limitations on the length of evaluation reports, this report provides only a short summary of the most relevant aspects.

Description and history

Located northwest of Nablus, in the West Bank, the nominated property is a multi-layered multi-period mound site that preserves archaeological and architectural vestiges that testify to its occupation by different civilisations, with different intensity, over three millennia, from the 9th century BCE onwards.

The precise extent of the Iron Age settlement is uncertain. Substantial remains of a two-phase fortified palatial complex have been uncovered, dated based on pottery and artefacts to the 9th and 8th centuries BCE. The earliest remains, dated to the first half of the 9th century BCE, revealed remains of a terraced platform on which a large structure, interpreted as a royal palace, was erected. A courtyard and domestic buildings were also excavated. The early city was enclosed by a wall. Later, the acropolis was extended and the earlier wall replaced with a casemate fortification. After a period of decline, the royal quarter underwent substantial modifications during the first half of the 8th century BCE. Noteworthy finds include a large corpus of inscribed ostraca from the 8th century BCE, which provide valuable information regarding the administration and economy of the city, as well as numerous fragments of ivory furnishings and ivory objects, which are evidence of the wealth of the royal

treasury. The archaeological material dating from the later 8th century and the 7th century BCE is limited.

Archaeological evidence for the Hellenistic period confirms that the city functioned as a fortified urban centre of considerable importance and was equipped with massive new fortifications with round towers. Their remains are still visible, particularly in the western side of the site. The extent of the Hellenistic settlement is yet to be established.

In the 1st century BCE, a new city on the site was founded by Herod the Great. It was carefully planned and integrated into the irregular topography of the area. It was enclosed within a new circuit wall and featured a monumental temple dedicated to Augustus, almost directly above the former Iron Age royal quarter. Constructed around 25 BCE, the sanctuary was approached by a monumental staircase. The construction of the temple, of which only the foundations survive today, required extensive levelling works that resulted in the destruction of a substantial part of the earlier Iron Age remains. The large open area in the middle of the nominated property, currently used as a parking area, corresponds to the location of the ancient forum. Originally established during the Herodian period, the forum was extensively rebuilt under the Severan emperors. It was surrounded by colonnaded porticoes and associated with a basilica, forming the administrative and commercial centre of the Roman city. Today, the remains of the basilica and of a colonnaded street, which are the defining features of the city, are still preserved, as are sections of the city wall and remnants of the western gate. The stadium built by Herod is only partly excavated, as is the theatre dating from the 2nd century CE. Remains of the sanctuary dedicated to Kore constructed during the 3rd century CE include a rectangular temenos. A Roman mausoleum was found in the southeast section of the site.

For the Byzantine period, archaeological reports indicate that the summit of the hill was occupied until the 4th century, after which activity shifted to the lower town around and east of the Roman forum, where the modern village of Sebastia is still located. Remains on the site include primarily vestiges of a small church (The Church of the Head) dedicated to Saint John the Baptist, generally dated to the 6th century CE. During the 11th century CE, the church was rebuilt, which demonstrates the continuing importance of the sanctuary. A small crypt with a martyrium was added to the basilica in the 11th-12th century CE. The three-aisled basilica, believed to be the site of beheading of Saint John the Baptist, functioned as an important pilgrimage sanctuary.

During the medieval period, pilgrims continued to visit the city because of its association with Saint John the Baptist. From this period date the remains of a Crusader cathedral dedicated to the saint. Built at the site of an earlier Byzantine church, which itself was constructed over a Roman cemetery situated east of the Roman city walls, it is believed to have been erected over the supposed burial place of Saint John the Baptist and contains a crypt

associated with the veneration of the saint. Following the Muslim reconquest of the region, the building was partially transformed into a mosque in the 12th-13th century. The three apses were removed and the structure adapted for Islamic worship, while retaining much of its original architecture. The building suffered damage and partial destruction during the 15th century CE. After the conversion of the cathedral into the Nabi Yahya Mosque – Nabi Yahya being the Islamic equivalent and historical identification for Saint John the Baptist in Christianity – the monument has continued to fulfil a religious function, thereby preserving the sacred character of the place despite the change of religious tradition.

Ottoman period on the site is known mostly through the traditional houses (such as Dar alKayid or Bayt alHawwari), dating from the late 18th-19th century, preserved in the eastern section of the site, amidst the modern constructions of the present-day village of Sebastia.

The nominated property has an area of 79 ha, and a buffer zone of 63 ha.

Excavations have confirmed Early Bronze Age activity (ca. 3000 BCE) at the site, primarily through diagnostic pottery found in mixed fills beneath Iron Age structures. There is no evidence for Middle or Late Bronze Age settlement.

The archaeological material confirms the existence of a first-rank regional political centre during the 9th and 8th centuries BCE, which is widely considered to be the ancient city of Samaria. This identification rests on a convergence of topographical, archaeological, historical, and epigraphic evidence. While certain details remain debated, the archaeological remains, together with contemporary Assyrian and Moabite written sources, permit a cautious association between the monumental development of the site and the reigns of kings Omri and Ahab; the former mentioned in the Bible as the founder of the city of Samaria, the capital of the Northern Kingdom of Israel. In 722-720 BCE, the city fell to the Assyrians and ceased to be the capital of an independent kingdom. It became an administrative centre governed by an Assyrian official. Around 605 BCE, the city came under Babylonian control and was later incorporated into the Achaemenid Persian Empire. Historical sources demonstrate that Samaria was at that time a major urban centre – a hub for local agricultural products and imported goods from the coast. Following the conquest of the region by Alexander the Great in 332 BCE, the city was integrated into the wider religious and cultural networks of the Hellenistic eastern Mediterranean. The city was ruled by the Ptolemies until 198 BCE, then by the Seleucids, before being captured by the Hasmonaeans and probably widely destroyed in 107 BCE. It was revived after Roman intervention in 63 BCE, integrated into the Roman province of Syria, and in 30 BCE given to Herod, who renamed it Sebaste, the Greek equivalent of the Latin title Augustus, which had been conferred upon Octavian. The identification of Sebaste with Samaria is possible thanks to late antique

sources, including the accounts of the pilgrim Egeria, who visited Palestine in the 4th century CE and expressly referred to “Sebaste, formerly called Samaria”, as well as to Saint Jerome. The modern name Sebastia derives from the Roman name. During the Roman period, Sebaste continued to develop and eventually acquired the status of a Roman colony under Septimius Severus. This development marked the final major phase of prosperity in the ancient history of the city and was accompanied by substantial urban renewal. The importance of Roman Sebaste declined during the Late Roman and Byzantine periods, when the city served as a seat of a bishopric. The principal written sources for this period derive from pilgrimage accounts. Pilgrimage was primarily associated with the veneration of Saint John the Baptist, whose martyrdom and burial from the 4th century CE onwards were associated by Christian tradition with the site, despite the fact that historian Flavius Josephus placed the execution of the saint at Machaerus, in present-day Jordan, and other places around the world are asserted to be the resting place(s) of elements of the remains of Saint John the Baptist.

There is little evidence for occupation of Sebastia during the Early Islamic period, and only limited activity until the Crusader period, when the site became a fortified village with a large cathedral. Thereafter, until the modern period, Sebastia was a small farming village, not urban in character. In the Late Ottoman period it was one of the so-called “Throne Villages”, an administrative domain (sheikdom) ruled by sheikhs who belonged to rich or noble families. The present-day village of Sebastia sits on the remains of the past centuries in the eastern part of the nominated property.

State of conservation

The nominated property has been subject to a considerable amount of archaeological investigation, but substantial portions of the site remain unexplored.

Principal excavations took place in 1908-1910 (G. Schumacher, G. A. Reisner, C. S. Fisher), 1931-1935 (J. W. Crowfoot, K. Kenyon), 1965-1967 (F. Zayadine), 1968 (J.B. Hennessy). In 2005 and later in 2010-2012, excavations were reopened by the Al-Quds University, working with partners. Multiple campaigns by the French Institute for Research followed in the years 2013-2018.

It is noteworthy that the oldest remains have been partly damaged in the process of historical development of the site. Moreover, a large part of the Iron Age structures was reburied after the excavations for protection. Currently, only few Iron Age walls and a Hellenistic tower defending the acropolis are perceptible among the later archaeological evidence, which dominates on the site.

The site experienced earthquakes in the past that damaged its remains. The archaeological vestiges have been further affected by erosion and surface deterioration due to exposure to the elements. The part of the nominated property west of the Roman forum (Area C) generally suffers from a lack of systematic maintenance.

The 2020 Conservation Master Plan describes it as abandoned without control, with weeds growing among the ancient stones, showing a complete lack of landscape management. The eastern section, where the present-day village is located, has benefited from conservation and rehabilitation efforts. Since 2006, local authorities have undertaken multiple targeted conservation interventions aimed at stabilisation of the structures and rehabilitation of public spaces.

As indicated by the State Party in the nomination dossier and additional information of May 2026, particularly in the past six years, the site has experienced repeated Israeli interventions, aimed at disconnecting the western section of the site from the eastern one and the current village, limiting Palestinian access, and undermining local conservation efforts. In 2025, new archaeological investigations were launched by the Archaeology Unit of the Israeli Civil Administration, responsible for managing antiquities and heritage sites across the West Bank in the Area C.

Based on the information provided by the State Party, ICOMOS considers that the state of conservation of the nominated property seems to be stable but vulnerable, and uneven across the site. This was not checked by a mission on-site.

Factors affecting the nominated property

Based on the information provided by the State Party, ICOMOS considers that the main factors affecting the nominated property are environmental (erosion, vegetation) and human-made, related to the development pressures as well as the ongoing Israeli-Palestinian conflict.

The nominated property is threatened not only by natural deterioration and insufficient maintenance but also by the current planning and governance conditions surrounding the archaeological area. While the State Party has established important legal, institutional, and planning frameworks for the protection of the nominated property, the operational implementation of these mechanisms continues to face significant constraints. Unilateral Israeli civil and security control over the western part of the nominated property (Area C) prevents the Palestinian authorities from implementing necessary protection measures. The fragmented governance structure hinders effective conservation. Unauthorised interventions including archaeological excavations by the Israeli Civil Administration, as well as looting and deliberate vandalism, resulting from uncontrolled access to the site have been reported. Additionally, negative impacts of military activities and settler incursions within and around the archaeological area have been indicated. Increased risks associated with the political instrumentalisation of archaeology and with competing territorial claims have been raised as concerns, among them the recently proposed land expropriation orders, issued in November 2025 and February 2026, and the redevelopment schemes which aim to create the Shomron National Park on the site.

ICOMOS considers that the state of conservation seems sufficient but uneven and vulnerable, and that factors affecting the nominated property, especially those resulting from human activities, require urgent action. These elements have not been checked by a mission on-site

3 Proposed justification for inscription

Proposed justification

The nominated property is considered by the State Party to be of Outstanding Universal Value as a cultural property for the following reasons:

- Sebastia testifies to the continuous urban narrative spanning over three millennia, from the Iron Age, when it was a prominent regional centre, through the Hellenistic period, when it became a fortified stronghold, the Roman period when the city flourished, to its role as a Byzantine bishopric, up to the Islamic and medieval periods, and finally the Ottoman era, when it was designated a “Throne Village”.
- The nominated property acted as a central point for political power and cultural exchange in the Eastern Mediterranean thanks to its geographical position at the crossroads of major trade routes. Its layered architectural fabric demonstrates the interchange of human values by the way it adapted foreign imperial models to the local conditions of the hilly topography.
- Through successive cultural layers, the landscape of Sebastia testifies to the uninterrupted amalgamation of cultures, reflected in the evolution of technologies and architectural forms, as well as an enduring spirituality that transcends religious dogmas.

Based on the nomination dossier, and according to the State Party, the key attributes of the proposed Outstanding Universal Value are the archaeological remains from all the periods documented on the site, dating from the Iron Age up until and including the domestic architecture of the Ottoman era.

Comparative analysis

The comparative analysis has been developed around three aspects: adaptation of Hellenistic military architecture and Roman urban planning to complex topography; multi-period urban continuity; and layering of sacred traditions from Antiquity through the Islamic period. The comparative analysis has examined properties within the geo-cultural region, understood as Eastern Mediterranean, inscribed on the World Heritage List, included in the Tentative Lists of States Parties as well as other properties, without a clearly defined historical period but generally representing different chronological timeframes from the Iron Age onwards. The comparative analysis includes a qualitative assessment of the comparative exercise.

ICOMOS considers that the most appropriate comparative geo-cultural area is the Levant region, but wider territory of the Hellenistic and Roman empires should have been taken into consideration as well. Within this area, it would have been relevant to consider urban centres that were established and developed between the 9th century BCE and the 12th century CE, and that have continued to be inhabited until the present day or very recent past. Regarding the third proposed theme, ICOMOS considers that it would have been preferable to prepare the comparative analysis on a global scale.

Within the Levant region alone, ICOMOS considers that the presented comparative analysis has substantial gaps.

Within the first theme proposed by the State Party, there are numerous other relevant comparative properties in the Levant that could have been taken into consideration, including: Byblos (Lebanon, 1984, criteria (iii), (iv), and (vi)); the Old City of Jerusalem and its Walls (Jerusalem (Site proposed by Jordan); 1981, criteria (ii), (iii), (vi)); the Ancient City of Damascus (Syrian Arab Republic, 1979, criteria (i), (ii), (iii), (iv), and (vi)); the Ancient City of Aleppo (Syrian Arab Republic, 1986, criteria (iii) and (iv)); as well as the area of Jericho (State of Palestine). Within this selection alone, Sebastia's fortifications and urban plan in the Hellenistic and Roman periods, while significant, are not exceptional in the regional context. The city can be described as having a Hellenistic acropolis at its core, with a subsequent Roman street pattern adapted to suit the steep hill onto which it was laid out. Thus, the fabric and plan of the city were the result of widely understood and widely used approaches to urban planning that had been implemented not only across the southern Levant, but also across the wider Hellenistic and Roman empires. For instance, similar approaches to urban planning (terracing and/or curved streets) were used at hilly sites in places like Dougga/Thugga (Tunisia, 1997, criteria (ii) and (iii)), or the Pergamon and its Multi-Layered Cultural Landscape (Türkiye, 2014, criteria (i), (ii), (iii), (iv) and (vi)), to name a few.

The second set of comparator sites are those that demonstrate continuity of occupation and use over considerable periods. This includes all of the sites mentioned above, together with the Biblical Tels – Megiddo, Hazor, Beer Sheva (Israel, 2005, criteria (ii), (iii), (iv) et (vi)), Tell Jezreel (Israel), and the Old Town of Nablus and its environs (State of Palestine, Tentative List). Within this context, Sebastia can be considered a comparable site, in that it has been inhabited for millennia. However, it is not outstanding. Within the Levant, cities such as Byblos, Damascus, Jerusalem, or Aleppo possess comparable, and in some cases stronger, claims to long-term urban continuity. The distinctiveness of the nominated property therefore does not lie in the duration of occupation. Rather, it resides in the exceptional legibility of the principal historical phases in this long process within a single layered archaeological landscape that reflects the successive waves of occupation and acculturation. Unlike many continuously inhabited cities where successive urban development has obscured

earlier remains, Sebastia preserves a relatively direct archaeological record of its major periods of development, namely during the Iron Age, the Hellenistic and Roman periods, up to the Byzantine period, with the later additions particularly from the Crusader era.

Regarding the third aspect considered in the comparative analysis, namely sites of polytheistic religious importance within the State of Palestine and in the immediately adjacent region, there are a number of sites of significance to more than one religious tradition that should be compared with Sebastia. In terms of the layering of sacred tradition, and in association with the authenticity of the tradition as well as the continuity of shared usage, relevant comparisons could be made with the following properties: the Birthplace of Jesus: Church of the Nativity and the Pilgrimage Route, Bethlehem (State of Palestine, 2012, (iv) and (vi)); Rachel's Tomb / Qubbat Rahil (State of Palestine); the Mosque of Bilal ibn Rabah (State of Palestine); the Shrine of alKhader / Mar Elias / Cave of Elijah Mount Carmel (Israel); the Old City of Jerusalem and its Walls (Jerusalem (Site proposed by Jordan), 1981, criteria (ii), (iii) and (vi)); Ibrahimi Mosque / Tombs of the Patriarchs in Hebron (within the property of Hebron/Al-Khalil Old Town, State of Palestine, 2017, criteria (ii), (iv) and (vi)). It would also be important to make comparisons with inscribed properties that function as significant sites of pilgrimage elsewhere in the world.

When compared with these other sites of significance to multiple religious traditions within the region, the nominated property could potentially be considered outstanding as a site associated with prophet John the Baptist / Yahya, revered in both Christian and Islamic traditions, but the claim would need to be further substantiated. This association is based on the traditional belief that the place represents the site of martyrdom and burial of the saint, which prompted pilgrimage to Sebastia. As several other sanctuaries throughout the Christian world claim relics of the saint, the significance of Sebastia could potentially be argued based not on the exclusivity of this claim, but rather from the continuity of religious practice, collective memory, pilgrimage, and sacred tradition centred upon the same location over many centuries. However, at this stage scant evidence of the uninterrupted nature of this tradition and religious practice has been presented; pilgrimage to the site is well attested for the Late Antique and Middle Age periods but not well documented for later periods, to claim unequivocally its continuity since the 4th century CE.

ICOMOS considers that, despite substantial gaps and lack of balance in certain areas, the comparative analysis justifies consideration of this property for the World Heritage List, albeit for reasons different than proposed by the State Party.

Criteria under which inscription is proposed

The property is nominated on the basis of criteria (ii), (iii) and (vi).

Criterion (ii): exhibit an important interchange of human values, over a span of time or within a cultural area of the world, on developments in architecture or technology, monumental arts, town-planning or landscape design;

This criterion is justified by the State Party on the grounds that the nominated property, through its built fabric preserved from three millennia of occupation of the site, reflects the interchange of human values in military engineering, architecture and urban planning across the Eastern Mediterranean. The Iron Age objects excavated on the site testify to trade with outside powers which resulted in artistic exchanges. The adaptation of Hellenistic military architecture and Roman urban planning laid over local topography demonstrate syntheses of foreign models with local traditions.

ICOMOS considers that for this criterion to be justified, the interchange and the values/influence need to be substantial in their impact on the recipient culture, and must have prompted a response, which can be said to be outstanding in terms of the influence it had at the time and/or subsequently on people or society. It further needs to be embodied in the attributes of the nominated property. While the objects recovered from the Iron Age layers may testify to trade exchanges, these moveable artefacts cannot be considered attributes of the nominated property, as the World Heritage Convention is a site-based Convention. Moreover, while they may testify to time-specific cultural exchanges between cultures, the influence of these exchanges in the broader region or over time is not demonstrated. Regarding adaptations in architecture and urban planning, the Hellenistic fortifications that are the result of adaptation of Greek military concepts to the Levantine context, and the archaeological or architectural features of Roman town planning in the nominated property, while significant, have not been demonstrated to be exceptional in the regional context as a representation of an exceptional interchange of human values. The fabric and plan of the city were the result of widely understood and widely used approaches to urban planning that had been implemented not only across the southern Levant, but across the wider Hellenistic and Roman empires. It is not possible in this case to speak of foreign and local influences being merged into some sort of innovative or exceptional synthesis that later influenced similar developments elsewhere. Moreover, while the argument of the State Party is made based on three millennia of occupation of the site, proposed examples of interchange do not go beyond the Roman period.

ICOMOS considers that this criterion is not demonstrated.

Criterion (iii): *bear a unique or at least exceptional testimony to a cultural tradition or to a civilization which is living or which has disappeared;*

This criterion is justified by the State Party on the basis of a multiperiod urban continuity from the Bronze Age to present-day Sebastia. The three millennia of successive civilisations and cultural traditions, characteristic of the southern Levant, are said to be a testimony to cultural resilience and amalgamation in the State of Palestine.

ICOMOS considers that the nominated property is not convincingly differentiated from other multiperiod urban properties in the geo-cultural region. It is not unusual for sites in the Levant to persist as significant places for millennia. Moreover, the nomination dossier does not demonstrate uninterrupted inhabitation of Sebastia from the Bronze Age; the site appears to have been unoccupied during the Middle and Late Bronze ages. The continuous urban narrative is demonstrated as commencing from the Iron Age (Iron Age II – 9th century BCE) and at this stage can be proven until the Byzantine period, potentially later, with gaps in evidence for the Early Islamic period. This chronology or even longer continued inhabitation is found at many cities in the region that have developed as tell sites. Many of these antique cities have remained important urban centres until today, while Sebastia since the medieval period was more of a village than a city. It is possible that if excavations were to resume, much more evidence from all periods could be discovered at the site but at this stage this cannot be confirmed to substantiate justification for criterion (iii), as proposed by the State Party.

ICOMOS further considers that the exceptional nature of the nominated property lies rather in the extant legibility within a single, layered archaeological site of the settlement formation and urban form that testify to the principal historical phases of occupation of the site – the Iron Age, the Hellenistic and the Roman periods, as well as the Byzantine period, with additional evidence from the Crusader era – and reflect the successive waves of inhabitation and cultural mixing. Unlike many continuously inhabited cities where successive urban development has obscured earlier remains, Sebastia preserves a relatively direct archaeological record of its major periods of development. Few sites in the Levant permit such a clear reading of successive political, religious, and urban systems that remain physically interconnected. Finally, located mainly in an agricultural area, the nominated property offers an exceptional potential, without real equivalent, for scientific exploration and knowledge.

ICOMOS considers that this criterion is demonstrated.

Criterion (vi): *be directly or tangibly associated with events or living traditions, with ideas, or with beliefs, with artistic and literary works of outstanding universal significance;*

This criterion is proposed on the basis of the layering of sacred traditions from the Byzantine period through the Islamic period related to the syncretic veneration of the

significant figure of Saint John the Baptist, also known as Prophet Yahya, at the same location in both Christian and Islamic traditions.

ICOMOS considers that this spiritual dimension of the nominated property is interesting. Sebastia, and in particular the Cathedral of Saint John the Baptist/Mosque of Nabi Yahya, appears to bear material witness to shared Christian and Islamic veneration of Saint John the Baptist/Nabi Yahya, as a place associated with his martyrdom and burial. The tradition related to the location of the tomb of Saint John the Baptist in Sebastia is attested since the end of the 4th century CE. However, there are several other sanctuaries throughout the Christian world that claim relics of the saint and a documented tradition connecting a specific place with his memory. Therefore, to justify this criterion, the specific significance of Sebastia would have to be demonstrated not based on the exclusivity of this association, but rather its longevity, and continuity of religious practice, collective memory, pilgrimage, and sacred tradition centred upon this location over many centuries. While substantial evidence exists that Sebastia's association with the revered figure has served as a focal point for pilgrimage, veneration, and religious experience in certain periods, the continuity of this tradition has not been fully demonstrated at this stage, based on the available documentation and research.

ICOMOS considers that this criterion is not demonstrated at this stage.

ICOMOS concurs with the identification of attributes proposed by the State Party but for a shorter chronological period – from the Iron Age until the Byzantine period, with additional evidence from the Crusader era.

ICOMOS considers that the nominated property meets criterion (iii), but that criteria (ii) and (vi) have not been demonstrated.

Integrity and authenticity

Integrity

The integrity of the nominated property is based on the inclusion of the layered structure of the site of Sebastia that preserves archaeological remains and architectural structures dating from the Iron Age onwards. Integrity is also a measure of the intactness of these remains which constitute the attributes conveying the proposed Outstanding Universal Value.

One of the most remarkable aspects of the nominated property is the visible coexistence, within a single site, of material traces left by the numerous civilisations that have occupied the site. Remains dating from the Iron Age, Hellenistic, Roman, and Byzantine periods, with later additions form a coherent ensemble whose historical development remains unusually clear. Nevertheless, the site presents certain vulnerabilities. In several sectors,

particularly on the acropolis, the combined effects of weathering, erosion, vegetation growth, and prolonged exposure of excavated remains are visible. Targeted consolidation measures, regular maintenance, and improved water management would significantly enhance the long-term preservation of the archaeological vestiges. These, however, are challenging to implement due to the division of the site in terms of management between the heritage authorities of the State Party and the Israeli Civil Administration, which has unilateral control over the western section of the nominated property (Area C).

Moreover, the integrity of the site is currently threatened by the expropriation plans, as stipulated in the orders issued by the Israeli Civil Administration in November 2025 and February 2026, which would result in the division of the nominated property and separation of its western section from the rest of the site in order to develop the area and create the Shomron National Park.

ICOMOS acknowledges that there is strong possibility that substantial archaeological deposits remain unexcavated beneath the present village and surrounding areas. The current boundaries are based on the known extent of archaeological vestiges and largely follows the Roman city wall, while including also the documented remains outside of it. However, in the absence of a technical evaluation mission, ICOMOS has been unable to fully evaluate the integrity of the nominated property or its potential vulnerabilities.

Authenticity

The authenticity of the nominated property is based on the form and design as well as location and setting of the multi-period archaeological and architectural vestiges dating from the Iron Age onwards. Authenticity depends on the degree of credibility and truthfulness of information sources on the value of the nominated property. These sources of information must be considered and judged primarily within the cultural contexts to which they belong.

The different historical layers within the nominated property remain legible and continue to communicate the heritage values that underpin the significance of the site through the preserved vestiges. It should, however, be noted that, some of the oldest evidence has been damaged in the process of historical development, as subsequent civilisations built on top of the previous ones, sometimes reusing the structures and other times reusing the materials. Moreover, the priorities of the 20th-century excavations meant that focus was mainly on Classical remains, to the detriment of later vestiges.

In the absence of a technical evaluation mission, ICOMOS has been unable to evaluate fully the authenticity of the nominated property or its potential vulnerabilities.

In conclusion, ICOMOS considers that the conditions of integrity and authenticity of the nominated property could not be fully evaluated.

Boundaries

There are approximately 1,300 inhabitants in the nominated property and 700 within the buffer zone (2026 estimation).

The boundaries of the nominated property have been defined by the extent of the documented archaeological vestiges and follow largely the perimeter of the Roman city wall, with additional areas outside of it, in the eastern section of the site, where the Cathedral of Saint John the Baptist/Mosque of Nabi Yahya was built over an earlier Byzantine church, the latter constructed at the site of a still earlier Roman cemetery.

The buffer zone encompasses the surrounding agricultural landscape. In the additional information of May 2026, the State Party clarified that the buffer zone has been established based on topographical, archaeological, visual, and urban planning considerations, taking into account the interrelationship between the archaeological remains, the historic urban fabric of Sebastia, the surrounding agricultural terraces, and the principal view corridors that contribute to the proposed Outstanding Universal Value of the nominated property. The buffer zone is intended to provide an added layer of protection and regulatory control over future urban development, land-use changes, and visual impacts affecting the setting of the nominated property.

ICOMOS considers that while the delimitation of the nominated property is logical, as it is based on the archaeological material documented at the site, the way the perimeter of the buffer zone has been defined is not entirely clear. While ICOMOS acknowledges the varied aspects considered, it is impossible at this stage, and without a technical evaluation mission to the site, to evaluate fully the suitability of the buffer zone; for instance, it is unclear what kind of studies were undertaken to establish the potential visual impacts on the nominated property or what kind of archaeological evidence was considered.

Evaluation of the proposed justification for inscription

In summary, ICOMOS considers that the comparative analysis has gaps but allows to consider the nominated property outstanding among its closest comparators on the basis of criterion (iii), although with a slightly different justification than proposed by the State Party. Criteria (ii) and (vi) have not been demonstrated. Conditions of integrity and authenticity could not be fully confirmed due to the absence of the technical evaluation mission. However, the site appears to present a number of vulnerabilities related both to a lack of regular maintenance, management challenges, as well as direct threats of the site's expected partition.

4 Conservation measures and monitoring

Documentation

The nominated property has been subject to archaeological investigation until the 1960s, with additional archaeological and conservation campaigns taking place in the past fifteen years.

In the additional information of May 2026, the State Party explained that extensive archaeological and conservation documentation from these works is in place and includes excavation reports, conservation reports, archaeological surveys, architectural drawings, site plans, photographic archives, GIS data, historical records, condition assessment reports, and technical studies related to both the archaeological remains and the architectural structures preserved from later periods. The documentation is held by varied institutions, including the Ministry of Tourism and Antiquities, Sebastia Municipality, the Jericho Mosaic Centre, Al-Quds University, the UNESCO Ramallah Office. The artefacts excavated at the site have been inventoried and are held by different institutions in the country and abroad. The Iron Age ostraca are kept at the Archaeological Museum of Istanbul in Istanbul, Türkiye. The collection of the carved ivory objects from Samaria has been dispersed among several institutions: the British Museum (United Kingdom), the Israel Museum (Israel), the Harvard Semitic Museum (United States of America), and the Institute für Archäologische Wissenschaften (Switzerland).

Conservation measures

While targeted conservation projects have been undertaken at the site in the past, the shift from isolated restoration to the development of the Conservation and Management Plan (CMP) in 2020 allowed for a more holistic approach that aims to balance protection of the archaeological and architectural vestiges, with urban functionality and community development.

ICOMOS notes, however, that the nominated property faces serious challenges in terms of maintenance and conservation due to the governance structure that divides the site – the eastern part being under Palestinian heritage authorities' management, while the western remains controlled by the Israeli side. Accordingly, conservation measures established by the State Party are not implemented in the large part of the nominated property, which appears to suffer from neglect but is also negatively affected by unauthorised excavations, development projects and damaged using heavy equipment, as reported by the State Party in the additional information sent in May 2026.

Furthermore, while the existence of the CMP of 2020 is noted, ICOMOS considers that it is unclear when the most recent state of conservation assessment of the nominated property was undertaken that could inform further planning.

Monitoring

The proposed monitoring system is linked to the conservation of the nominated property's attributes and wider landscape setting. ICOMOS observes that while it includes qualitative assessment related to the environmental threats, it is nevertheless heavily relying on quantitative record of completed activities, which cannot be easily used for planning purposes or inform preventive action. Moreover, the monitoring systems would benefit from further operational strengthening through the development of measurable baseline datasets, systematic documentation protocols, and more regular condition assessments covering the nominated property. The annual schedule of most monitoring activities currently proposed does not seem sufficient considering the type of threats the nominated property is facing. Attention should be given to the continuous monitoring of environmental degradation, urban expansion, visual impacts, and damage resulting from repeated incursions and unauthorised activities within the site and its buffer zone.

ICOMOS considers that the basic archaeological and conservation documentation is in place, however it is unclear whether a state of conservation assessment of the attributes of the nominated property has been undertaken by the State Party in the recent years to serve as the baseline for further management, conservation and monitoring planning. At the same time, ICOMOS considers that any conservation initiatives are currently hindered due to the governance challenges, thus a holistic approach for the site appears to be impossible to implement at the moment.

ICOMOS considers that it would be advisable that the monitoring system is developed further and adapted for easy integration of its outcomes into the Periodic Reporting questionnaire

In the absence of a technical evaluation mission, it has not been possible to assess the potential effectiveness of the conservation and monitoring measures put forward in the nomination dossier or their current implementation.

5 Protection and management

Legal protection

The nominated property is protected by the Decree Law of Tangible Cultural Heritage (No. 11, 2018). The Ministry of Tourism and Antiquities (MoTA) has the primary legal responsibility for its management and conservation. According to this Law, any major intervention, including conservation activities and excavations, must first be approved by the MoTA, and, when required, new structures or major changes in the areas of the nominated property or the buffer zone should undergo an Environmental and Heritage Impact Assessment.

The Buildings and Planning Law (No. 79, 1966), overseen by the Ministry of Local Government (MoLG), is in force

and implemented by the Sebastia Municipality. It provides regulations regarding building sites and stops any construction where an archaeological discovery has been made. The Law of Environment (No. 7, 1999) prohibits acts that would have negative impact on archaeological sites, including their visual aesthetics.

The nominated property and the buffer zone are classified as a protected archaeological area on the 2018 Municipal Spatial Master Plan (also called Sebastia Urban Master Plan). It provides a framework for spatial development of Sebastia, while ensuring protection of the nominated property. No excavations, damage, construction of public or private buildings, or road expansion may be undertaken within the protected archaeological area without prior written authorisation from the Department of Antiquities at the MoTA. Furthermore, no demolition, alteration, or modification affecting the historic urban fabric in the eastern section of the site may be conducted without the prior written approval of the said Department. At the local level, the nominated property is further subject to the Strategic Development Plan for the Town of Sebastia (2023-2026), in which the heritage protection is integrated with municipal development.

In the additional information of May 2026, the State Party assured that in case of inscription, the existing planning and regulatory framework, including the Municipal Spatial Master Plan of 2018 and the related planning regulations, may be reviewed and updated to provide more effective protection for the nominated property and its buffer zone.

Management system

The nominated property is managed by the MoTA, who has the primary responsibility for the protection, management and conservation of the site, and its buffer zone, including the review and assessment of all proposed conservation interventions, development plans, and building permits. The management and development of the site are anchored in MoTA's Strategic Sector Plan (2025-2027).

The Ministry works in coordination with other authorities, including the Sebastia Municipality and the MoLG. The Sebastia Municipality oversees implementation of planning controls and coordinates with MoTA in the regulation of development activities. The MoLG provides additional support in terms of land-use planning.

In terms of land ownership, the nominated property and the buffer zone include both public and private property. Additionally, Islamic Waqf owns and manages the Cathedral of Saint John the Baptist/Mosque of Nabi Yahya and the tomb of Saint John the Baptist/Prophet Yahya. The private land within the nominated area is used for agriculture, residential, and a few tourism-related activities. Regardless of ownership, the MoTA has full legal authority over the heritage site to decide the proper use of the land, in line with the provisions of the Tangible Cultural Heritage Decree Law (No. 11, 2018). As the State Party clarified in the additional information of May 2026, while no formal agreements have been concluded with

the private landowners within the buffer zone, the existing municipal permitting procedures and heritage protection regulations provide the basis for controlling development activities.

In 2020, UNESCO, in collaboration with the MoTA, developed a Conservation and Management Plan (CMP). It includes an Action Plan and is valid until 2030. It will be revised upon potential inscription, as it was developed using boundaries different from those proposed in the nomination dossier. Prior to the CMP, an Integrated Planning for the Safeguarding of the Cultural Landscape of Sabastiya was prepared in 2012.

ICOMOS considers that while the management system is generally well established, its practical application is constrained by the existing territorial division of the site resulting from the Oslo Accords, which was intended to be a temporary measure. Accordingly, the site includes Area B (encompassing the eastern section of the nominated property), administered under Palestinian civil control and joint Israeli-Palestinian security control, and Area C (which covers the western part of the nominated property) where full Israeli control is exercised. The site is also explicitly referred to in the 1995 Oslo II agreement as being a site of archaeological and historical importance to the Israeli side. This separation of administrative authority over the site, and the ongoing conflict between the parties involved, make the protection and management of the nominated property not fully operational.

ICOMOS further considers that greater collaboration with a variety of stakeholders, and particularly local communities in the management of the site should also be envisaged.

ICOMOS also acknowledges that Heritage Impact Assessment is applicable through the Decree Law of Tangible Cultural Heritage (No. 11, 2018) and that this mechanism provides an opportunity to assess the impact of construction projects or any major changes on cultural heritage within the nominated property and its surroundings. It is used when required. It would be advisable that the procedures and format for Heritage Impact Assessments be consistent with the *Guidance and Toolkit for Impact Assessments in a World Heritage Context*, developed jointly by the World Heritage Centre and Advisory Bodies. Moreover, Heritage Impact Assessment should be conducted for any development project within the nominated property and its buffer zone, not solely when deemed necessary.

Effectiveness of the protection and management of the nominated property

In summary, ICOMOS considers that while adequate legal frameworks, additional planning instruments and conservation strategies formally exist, in the absence of a technical evaluation mission, it has not been possible to assess the potential effectiveness of the protection and management measures put forward in the nomination dossier or their current implementation. However, it has

been observed that the separation of administrative authority over the site, and the ongoing conflict between the parties involved, hinder the holistic protection and management of the nominated property. Greater collaboration with a variety of stakeholders, and particularly local communities in the management of the site should also be envisaged.

6 Emergency threats affecting the nominated property

The State Party has set out the following emergency threats as a reason for requesting an emergency inscription:

- Immediate threat of irreversible alteration of the nominated property linked to the plans by the Israeli Civil Administration to expropriate land in the western part of the site in order to transform it into Shomron National Park.
- Sebastia's archaeological site has been experiencing physical threats for many years, which intensified in the last six years, and include unauthorised excavations, archaeological vestiges being confiscated, use of heavy equipment on the site, and construction of new infrastructure.

The emergency nomination has been submitted following the issuing of orders by the Israeli Civil Administration on 12 November 2025 and 17 February 2026 to expropriate part of the nominated property and substantial amount of the surrounding land. The seizure of land will affect the archaeological remains, by severing the physical link between the western and eastern parts of the nominated property, leading to the loss of integrity (wholeness) of the site. It will also have consequences for the local population whose private lands used for agriculture will be appropriated, with new settlement infrastructure, expected in a short time.

The recent expropriation orders add to the continuing negative conditions in Sebastia related to the security situation in the region which have prevailed for a considerable time, and the complex administrative situation of the site resulting from its administrative division established by the Oslo Accords, which does not allow the State Party to exercise effective protection of the nominated property and implement the necessary conservation measures. The destructive interventions that have been documented in recent years include unauthorised excavations (photographic documentation from 2016, 2025), damage to ancient structures (photographic documentation from 2022) and confiscation of archaeological artefacts (2023), use of heavy equipment (such as bulldozers) on the site (2012, 2016, 2021), as well as new constructions (2016).

ICOMOS considers that there is a tangible risk that part of the archaeological site could be appropriated or managed in ways that alter its historical and cultural context. The

concerns raised in the nomination dossier are supported by verifiable evidence, including official administrative orders, maps, dated photographs, and other documents.

ICOMOS considers that the nominated property faces documented, imminent threats stemming from recent expropriation plans and land-seizure measures targeting the archaeological core of Sebastia. The expropriation decision explicitly authorises the immediate acquisition of disposal rights over the nominated property and its surrounding landscape. ICOMOS notes that these measures are no longer hypothetical or prospective in nature but constitute active administrative and territorial implementation processes supported by formal legal procedures, mapping systems, publication mechanisms, and planned physical interventions.

Accordingly, ICOMOS considers that the threats currently facing Sebastia constitute an emergency situation within the meaning of the *Operational Guidelines for the Implementation of the World Heritage Convention*. The nominated property is exposed to immediate, serious, and specific threats from human activities that endanger not only individual archaeological remains but the overall integrity of the nominated property as a multi-layered site with multi-period cultural history.

Additionally, in ICOMOS' opinion, the threats may be directly linked to the conditions described under paragraph 179(b)(i) of the *Operational Guidelines for the Implementation of the World Heritage Convention*, as they concern planned modification of the juridical status of the property and its protection regime, as well as paragraph 179(b)(iii) and (iv), concerning the threatening effects of regional planning, development, and management interventions. The proposed transformation of part of the nominated property into the Shomron National Park, including plans for fencing, altered access routes, visitor infrastructure, parking facilities, and new circulation systems, risks fundamentally altering the spatial and historical coherence between the western and eastern sections of the site.

ICOMOS also observes that the nominated property may already be experiencing serious deterioration, as described in paragraphs 179(a). The nomination dossier and the additional information shared in May 2026 demonstrate ongoing physical deterioration resulting from unauthorised excavations, looting, vandalism, inadequate maintenance, erosion, collapse of architectural elements, and repeated damage from military incursions and heavy machinery movements within the site, paired with the continuing inability of Palestinian authorities to undertake timely conservation, stabilisation, risk mitigation, and monitoring interventions due to restrictions on access and governance fragmentation imposed on the site.

Furthermore, ICOMOS considers that the current governance situation represents a structural management vacuum that critically undermines the implementation of conservation and protection measures in the nominated property. Although adequate legal frameworks, additional

planning instruments and conservation strategies formally exist, the fragmented administrative reality and restrictions imposed on access, intervention, and site management appear to systematically obstruct the effective implementation of these mechanisms on the ground. ICOMOS is particularly concerned that the cumulative impact of expropriation measures, territorial fragmentation, restricted access, unilateral archaeological interventions, and planned tourism restructuring may result in the irreversible transformation of the nominated property and its wider setting within a short timeframe.

7 Conclusion

In response to the requirements for emergency nominations set out in the *Operational Guidelines for the Implementation of the World Heritage Convention*, paragraphs 161-162, ICOMOS has examined whether:

- The nominated property is in danger, as a result of having suffered damage or facing serious and specific dangers from natural events or human activities, which would constitute an emergency situation;
- An immediate decision by the World Heritage Committee is necessary to ensure its safeguarding;
- The nominated property may unquestionably justify Outstanding Universal Value.

ICOMOS considers that the threats indicated by the State Party, and particularly the land expropriation orders of the Israeli Civil Administration and the site transformation plans, are of serious nature, and the dangers the nominated property faces constitute an emergency situation, necessitating an immediate decision by the World Heritage Committee. ICOMOS also acknowledges that while the ongoing physical deterioration and violations reported by the State Party have intensified in the recent years, they reflect a long-standing and complex political situation. Finally, ICOMOS considers that the ongoing conflict and the administrative situation of the nominated property have numerous impacts, including on the local population and their livelihood.

ICOMOS recommends that the nominated property be inscribed on the World Heritage List and, at the same time, on the List of World Heritage in Danger. This recommendation should be seen as a way to ensure that the attributes are not impacted by the threats related to the ongoing conflict in the West Bank, and particularly the planned division of the nominated property through land expropriation which would result in the loss of integrity of the archaeological site; that appropriate planning regulations are developed; that resources are mobilised to address conservation challenges; and that the protection, conservation, management and monitoring regimes for the nominated property are completed and implemented.

ICOMOS considers that an inscription on the World Heritage List in Danger should be the opportunity to gain the attention and support of the international community for the protection of the nominated property.

In view of the lack of a technical evaluation mission, ICOMOS has not been able to fully evaluate the justification proposed for Outstanding Universal Value in the nomination dossier, particularly in relation to integrity, authenticity and management, but does consider that there are potential vulnerabilities and weaknesses in the case as presented.

ICOMOS considers that the dangers facing the nominated property constitute an emergency situation for which a decision by the World Heritage Committee is necessary for its safeguarding, and that the Outstanding Universal Value of the nominated property has been demonstrated.

8 Recommendations

Recommendations with respect to inscription

ICOMOS recommends that Sebastia, State of Palestine, be inscribed on an emergency basis on the World Heritage List on the basis of **criterion (iii)** and at the same time on the List of World Heritage in Danger.

ICOMOS recommends that a Reactive Monitoring mission be invited to the property, if this is feasible, to establish a Desired state of conservation and a programme of corrective measures to remove the property from the List of World Heritage in Danger.

Recommended Statement of Outstanding Universal Value

Brief synthesis

Located northwest of Nablus, in the West Bank, Sebastia is a multi-period mound site that preserves archaeological and architectural vestiges that testify to its occupation by different civilisations, with different intensity, from the 9th century BCE. The layered structure of the property includes remains that testify to the inhabitation of the site in the Iron Age, when it was a prominent regional political centre, widely identified with the ancient city of Samaria; to the Hellenistic period, when it became a fortified stronghold; to the Roman period when the city was renamed Sebaste by Herod and acquired the status of a Roman colony under Septimius Severus; to the Byzantine period when the importance of the city declined but it became a seat of a bishopric; and finally to later historical phases dating to the medieval period (especially the Crusader era) and the Ottoman era. The successive cultural layers allow to trace the political, religious and urban history of Samaria/Sebaste, while still offering an exceptional potential for future scientific research.

Criterion (iii): The visible coexistence, within a single archaeological site, and the exceptional legibility of material traces left by the successive civilisations that

occupied this place from the Iron Age, through the Hellenistic and Roman periods, to the Byzantine period, as well as later additions from the Crusader era, makes Sebastia stand out within the Levant region. With its multi-layered character and multi-period evidence, the property represents a coherent ensemble that testifies to the principal historical phases of the settlement of the site. Unlike many continuously inhabited cities where successive urban development has obscured earlier remains, Sebastia preserves relatively direct archaeological traces of its major periods of development which allows for a clear reading of successive political, religious, and urban systems that remain physically interconnected.

Integrity

The multi-layered site of Sebastia includes all the known archaeological remains and architectural structures that testify to the occupation of the site from the Iron Age until the Byzantine period, as well as several notable Crusader period vestiges. The physical conditions of the property could not have been fully evaluated at the time of inscription due to the lack of a technical evaluation mission, but the state of its physical fabric seems to be uneven, with some sections of the property in a worse state than others due to the combined effects of weathering, erosion, vegetation growth, and prolonged exposure of excavated remains. The integrity of the site is currently threatened by the land expropriation plans, aimed at dividing the property and developing the Shomron National Park in its western section. Considering further the existing threats related to the ongoing Israeli-Palestinian conflict and the developmental pressures, the integrity of the property can be considered as highly vulnerable.

Authenticity

The different historical layers within the property remain legible and continue to communicate the heritage values that underpin the significance of the site through the preserved vestiges, even if the earliest archaeological evidence has been partially damaged by subsequent historical developments, since the successive civilisations built their cities amidst or on top of the previous ones. In the absence of a technical evaluation mission, the full assessment of the authenticity of the property was not possible at the time of inscription.

Protection and management requirements

The property is protected by the Decree Law of Tangible Cultural Heritage (No. 11, 2018), and its protection, management and conservation are overseen by the Ministry of Tourism and Antiquities. The Sebastia Municipality oversees implementation of planning controls and coordinates with the Ministry in the regulation of development activities. The site is included as a protected area within the 2018 Municipal Spatial Master Plan and is managed through the 2020 Conservation and Management Plan; both of these documents will be revised to ensure the effective protection of the property in accordance with the approved boundaries. While

adequate legal frameworks, additional planning instruments and conservation strategies formally exist, the practical application of the governance system is constrained by the existing territorial division of the site into Area B (administered under Palestinian civil control and joint Israeli-Palestinian security control) and Area C (under full Israeli control) resulting from the Oslo Accords, which was intended to be a temporary measure.

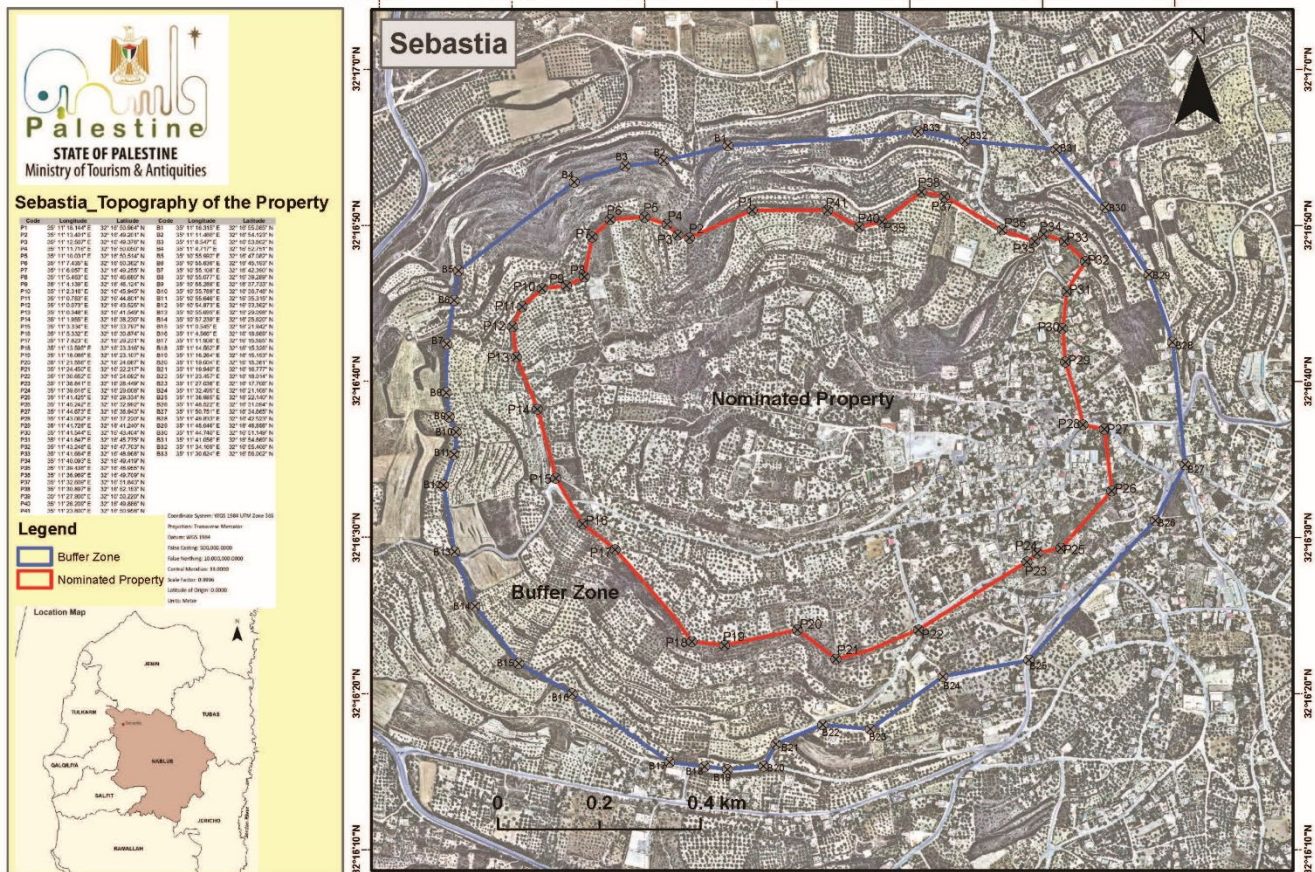
Additional recommendations

ICOMOS further recommends that the State Party give urgent consideration to the following:

- a) Conducting an assessment of the state of conservation of the attributes of the property to serve as a baseline for management, conservation and monitoring planning,
- b) Developing further the monitoring system based on the comprehensive inventory of attributes and their assessment, and taking into consideration the existing threats,
- c) Updating the 2020 Conservation and Management Plan based on the approved boundaries of the property and its buffer zone, and the state of conservation assessment of the attributes, and implementing the Plan across the property,
- d) Revising the existing planning and regulatory frameworks, including the Municipal Spatial Master Plan of 2018 to incorporate the approved boundaries of the property and its buffer zone and ensure effective protection of the property,
- e) Considering preparing a research plan, including conducting further archaeological survey of the area and possibly also excavations, when possible, to confirm the boundaries of the city in the different historical periods and the extent of archaeological vestiges preserved on the site,
- f) Establishing an inclusive governance framework based on rights-based approach that would ensure greater collaboration in the management of the property, and particularly with local communities,
- g) Informing the World Heritage Centre of the intention to undertake or authorise any major projects which may affect the Outstanding Universal Value of the property, in line with paragraph 172 of *Operational Guidelines for the Implementation of the World Heritage Convention*,
- h) Ensuring that the procedures and format for Heritage Impact Assessment are consistent with the *Guidance and Toolkit for Impact Assessments in a World Heritage Context* and

that Heritage Impact Assessment is conducted before any development project within the property, its buffer zone and its immediate setting,

- i) Submitting to the World Heritage Centre by 1 February 2027, a report on the implementation of the above-mentioned recommendations for examination by the World Heritage Committee at its 49th session.



Map showing the boundaries of the nominated property

ICOMOS

INTERNATIONAL COUNCIL ON MONUMENTS AND SITES
CONSEIL INTERNATIONAL DES MONUMENTS ET DES SITES
CONSEJO INTERNACIONAL DE MONUMENTOS Y SITIOS

Our ref.GB/AES/1810/Emergency procedure

Charenton-le-Pont, 9 July 2026

Mr. Lazare Eloundou Assomo
Director of World Heritage
7 Place de Fontenoy
75007 Paris

Objet: Nomination submitted on an emergency basis -
“The Mount Amel Castles” (Lebanon)

Dear Director, dear Lazare,

I acknowledge receipt of the nomination of “The Mount Amel Castles”, submitted on an emergency basis by the Delegation of Lebanon, which was forwarded to ICOMOS on 23 June 2026.

I have asked my team to launch the evaluation process immediately, whilst recognising that organising a technical evaluation mission to the nominated property would not be feasible given the current security situation.

Please rest assured that we are fully committed to providing you with an ICOMOS evaluation report as soon as possible, in accordance with the minimum timeframe required by ICOMOS to evaluate nominations submitted on an emergency basis. The evaluation report is expected to be submitted to the World Heritage Centre in September 2026.

According to paragraph 162 of the *Operational Guidelines for the implementation of the World Heritage Convention*, ICOMOS is requested to assess the qualities of the nominated property which may justify its Outstanding Universal Value, the nature of the danger and the urgency of the decision by the World Heritage Committee.

At this stage of the procedure, ICOMOS has identified and contacted a group of international experts, including scholars of medieval history and Crusader-period history as well as archaeologists specialized on military architecture particularly in Crusader, Islamic, Byzantine, and European fortifications systems, as well as academics recognised for their research into other

aspects of the nominated property, so that they may provide their views and critical analysis of the potential Outstanding Universal Value of the nominated property, through desk review reports.

On the basis of certain issues and concerns identified in the nomination dossier, a letter was sent on 29 June 2026 to the State Party requesting further information on the significance of the nominated property, the integrated defensive network, the successive cultural change, the proposed boundaries for the nominated property and buffer zones, the comparative analysis, authenticity, integrity and reconstruction as well as management. The State Party provided additional information in reply to ICOMOS' request on 8 July 2026.

Furthermore, ICOMOS has also approached several other bodies, including ICOMOS Lebanon, to obtain information on the impact of the recent escalation of the conflict and threat to cultural heritage in southern Lebanon. As a result of the ongoing conflict, the five Mount Amel Castles are currently in a highly critical condition due to their proximity to military operations and their strategic positions. Paradoxically, the very values that contribute to the significance of these five castles (strategic military network) and contributed to their long-term survival (successive re-occupations), now threatens their very survival.

On 18 November 2024, provisional enhanced protection was granted individually to the five Castles of Mount Amel (alongside 68 other Lebanese sites) by the Committee for the Protection of Cultural Property in the Event of Armed Conflict at its 4th Extraordinary meeting at UNESCO Headquarters (UNESCO Decision No. C54/24/4.EXT.COM/4). Sites granted this status cannot be attacked or used for military purposes.

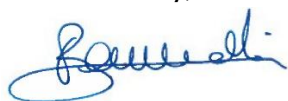
Once the relevant documentation had been gathered, the ICOMOS World Heritage Panel was consulted on the justification of the emergency of the nominated property. In light of available information, some of which cannot be fully verified at this stage in the absence of a technical evaluation mission to the five component parts of the nominated property, but which is sufficient and corroborated through varied sources to constitute a firm basis to draw well-informed conclusions, as well as supported by the decision of UNESCO in line with which the nominated property was put under enhanced protection on 18 November 2024, the ICOMOS World Heritage Panel confirmed on 7 July 2026 that despite some component parts of the nominated property of the Castles of Mount Amel (Qala'at Chama', Qala'at al-chakif, Qala'at Chakra, Qala'at Deir Kifa and Qala'at Tibnin) having suffered damage, the ongoing threats which these castles face, due to the ongoing armed conflict, are sufficiently serious to justify emergency procedure.

In addition, based on experience ICOMOS has had in dealing with post-recovery situations at heritage sites, it is highlighted that due consideration be given to all potential impacts associated with proposed interventions. Decrees and legal masterplans must explicitly integrate the boundaries and regulations governing the World Heritage buffer zones across all component parts. Clear, binding directives must be issued to control/prevent unregulated development, visual impacts, or unwarranted demolition of historical surroundings during emergency rebuilding. Mechanisms for building permit approvals within the buffer zones must be tightly enforced. Rapid deployment of dedicated funding will be key as well for successful post-conflict recovery.

To conclude, although the emergency of the nomination has been confirmed by the members of the ICOMOS World Heritage Panel, the time required to consult international experts, receive further information and convene the members of the ICOMOS World Heritage Panel to examine this information does not allow ICOMOS, at this stage, to formulate a recommendation as to whether the nominated property is likely to demonstrate, beyond doubt, Outstanding Universal Value.

I remain at your disposal to provide any further details you may require.

Yours faithfully,



Gwenaëlle Bourdin
Director
ICOMOS Evaluation Unit

Copy to: Ms. Teresa Patricio, ICOMOS President
Ms. Céline Noguès-Weber, ICOMOS Director General
Mr. Alessandro Balsamo, Head of Nominations Unit, World Heritage Centre